

The more things change...

I CAN'T BELIEVE THE 20TH ANNIVERSARY IS HERE ALREADY.

We've dropped the DVD because the poll we conducted that had many thousands of subscribers respond showed that over 85% were in favour of something else instead of the DVD. We will continue the eDVD of course, which you can access at geek.digit.in (write to help@digit.in if you're confused about how to do this).

Now, getting down to the topic of 2041, there are plenty of smarter people than me writing about what will change and how in the pages that follow. I'm going to focus my column on how little things actually change, or even if they do, how they mostly just mimic our own experiences.

Displays are essentially just poised to mimic your eyes. I expect AR will be very popular for everyday applications, because who doesn't want what's equivalent of bionic eyes? VR is where we will take our flights of fancy, but holograms are the real holy grail of displays. Let's face it, who wouldn't want the Holodeck from Star Trek inside their homes? However, the ultimate goal here for all of these technologies is to allow you to feel as if you're looking at something through your own eyes – which nature provided.

5G and IoT are buzzwords we're going to hear a lot more of in the next couple of years, but what they are essentially is much faster internet access for many more devices, and IoT is like every micro-manager's wet dream, with millions of little data points to track and control. All of those sensors and the analysis of their data is just like the human nervous system, and personally for you, the IoT devices you care about and connect to will essentially act like an extension of yourself.

What this pandemic has done is show us how much of our work was actually doable remotely, and it's shown corporations all over the globe that they can indeed survive without needing everyone to work in a centralised location. Of course security problems will come up by the thousands, but all of those are fixable problems. So many of us working across the globe have realised just how much of family life they've been missing, and how precious life is. Although it's possibly weird to start thinking of pandemic positives, I think a lot of us will find a better work-life balance, and choose to at least work part-time from home. Another return to

basics here, with a focus on family, something your parents or grandparents might have been telling you tales of from their time.

All of us are waiting for general AI to come along and do our bidding, even better if it can be implanted into a robot that can physically do our bidding – take over chores, cook, clean, and even satisfy us in other ways... Is that really different from the rich having "servants" or slavery in colonial times? All we're doing is hoping we will invent slaves that no one will feel guilty about exploiting.

The internet exposed us to so many different cultures, and we traveled the globe, only to promptly revert to talking our local language so that we could complain about how weird they are, and indulge in the same casual racism and xenophobia as before meeting them. A universal translator would be nice. Would force us to behave exactly as we do when everyone around us speaks the same language. That would truly make the world local! A return to the villages for us, except this would be a global village with billions of people.

I doubt much will change when it comes to socialising either, except that we might be able to do it from a distance. 2041 might be too soon for us to start living in a VR world (Matrix style), but that's surely coming. If your brain truly believes you are sitting with friends and having a good time, or alone in a romantic location with your partner, isn't that "reality"?

All of this will be powered by fusion reactors, because that's what works best in the natural world after all. We will build our own mini suns – you know, those things that have existed for a tad under 14 billion years? – and have as much power as we need. We can even power rockets with it and start exploring our solar system! A round trip to Mars could take as little as 2 months. And we'd probably colonise it and open up malls and parking lots there as well...

All of our technological advancements are just going to mimic nature, or the human condition, but the major difference between nature and the world we're building is that in our world, we are the gods in charge. Or so we think.

At a fundamental level, 2001 was not really that different from 2021, was it? Similarly, 2041 might not be as drastic a change from now as we like to imagine. The more things change, the more they stay the same... 🇺🇸



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